A typical HTTP session

In client-server protocols, like HTTP, sessions consist of three phases:

1. The client establishes a TCP connection (or the appropriate connection if the transport layer is not TCP).

2. The client sends its request and waits for the answer.

3. The server processes the request, sending back its answer, and providing a status code and appropriate data.

As of HTTP/1.1, the connection is no longer closed after completing the third phase, and the client is now granted a further request: this means the second and third phases can now be performed any number of times.

Establishing a connection

In client-server protocols, it is the client which establishes the connection. Opening a connection in HTTP means initiating a connection in the underlying transport layer, usually this is TCP.

With TCP the default port, for an HTTP server on a computer, is port 80. Other ports can also be used, like 8000 or 8080. The URL of a page to fetch contains both the domain name, and the port number, though the latter can be omitted if it is 80.

Note: The client-server model does not allow the server to send data to the client without an explicit request for it. To work around this problem, web developers use several techniques: ping the server periodically via the `XMLHTTPRequest`, `fetch()` APIs, using the WebSockets API, or similar protocols.

Sending a client request

Once the connection is established, the user-agent can send the request (a user-agent is typically a web browser, but can be anything else, a crawler, for example). A client request consists of text directives, separated by CRLF (carriage return, followed by line feed), divided into three blocks:

1. The first line contains a request method followed by its parameters:

    - the path of the document, as an absolute URL without the protocol or domain name
    - the HTTP protocol version

2. Subsequent lines represent an HTTP header, giving the server information about what type of data is appropriate (for example, what language, what MIME types), or other data altering its behavior (for example, not sending an answer if it is already cached). These HTTP headers form a block which ends with an empty line.

3. The final block is an optional data block, which may contain further data mainly used by the POST method.

Example requests

Fetching the root page of developer.mozilla.org, (`https://developer.mozilla.org/`), and telling the server that the user-agent would prefer the page in French, if possible:

```
GET / HTTP/1.1
Host: developer.mozilla.org
Accept-Language: fr
```

Observe that final empty line, this separates the data block from the header block. As there is no Content-Length provided in an HTTP header, this data block is presented empty, marking the end of the headers, and allowing the server to process the request the moment it receives this empty line.

For example, sending the result of a form:

```
POST /contact_form.php HTTP/1.1
Host: developer.mozilla.org
Content-Length: 64
Content-Type: application/x-www-form-urlencoded

name=Joe%20User&request=Send%20me%20one%20of%20your%20catalogue
```

Request methods

HTTP defines a set of request methods indicating the desired action to be performed upon a resource. Although they can also be nouns, these request methods are sometimes referred as HTTP verbs. The most common requests are `GET` and `POST`:

- The `GET` method requests a data representation of the specified resource. Requests using `GET` should only retrieve data.
- The `POST` method sends data to a server so it may change its state. This is the method often used for HTML Forms.

Structure of a server response

After the connected agent has sent its request, the web server processes it, and ultimately returns a response. Similar to a client request, a server response is formed of text directives, separated by CRLF, though divided into three blocks:

1. The first line, the *status line*, consists of an acknowledgment of the HTTP version used, followed by a response status code (and its brief meaning in human-readable text).

2. Subsequent lines represent specific HTTP headers, giving the client information about the data sent (for example, type, data size, compression algorithm used, hints about caching). Similarly to the block of HTTP headers for a client request, these HTTP headers form a block ending with an empty line.

3. The final block is a data block, which contains the optional data.

Example responses

Successful web page response:

```
HTTP/1.1 200 OK
Content-Type: text/html; charset=utf-8
Content-Length: 55743
Connection: keep-alive
Cache-Control: s-maxage=300, public, max-age=0
Content-Language: en-US
Date: Thu, 06 Dec 2018 17:37:18 GMT
```

```
ETag: "2e77ad1dc6ab0b53a2996dfd4653c1c3"
Server: meinheld/0.6.1
Strict-Transport-Security: max-age=63072000
X-Content-Type-Options: nosniff
X-Frame-Options: DENY
X-XSS-Protection: 1; mode=block
Vary: Accept-Encoding,Cookie
Age: 7

<!DOCTYPE html>
<html lang="en">
<head>
  <meta charset="utf-8">
  <title>A simple webpage</title>
</head>
<body>
  <h1>Simple HTML webpage</h1>
  <p>Hello, world!</p>
</body>
</html>
```

Notification that the requested resource has permanently moved:

```
HTTP/1.1 301 Moved Permanently
Server: Apache/2.4.37 (Red Hat)
Content-Type: text/html; charset=utf-8
Date: Thu, 06 Dec 2018 17:33:08 GMT
Location: https://developer.mozilla.org/ (this is the new link to the resource;
          it is expected that the user-agent will fetch it)
Keep-Alive: timeout=15, max=98
Accept-Ranges: bytes
Via: Moz-Cache-zlb05
Connection: Keep-Alive
Content-Length: 325 (the content contains a default page to display if the
                     user-agent is not able to follow the link)

<!DOCTYPE html>… (contains a site-customized page helping the user to find the
                  missing resource)
```

Notification that the requested resource doesn't exist:

```
HTTP/1.1 404 Not Found
Content-Type: text/html; charset=utf-8
Content-Length: 38217
Connection: keep-alive
Cache-Control: no-cache, no-store, must-revalidate, max-age=0
```

```
Content-Language: en-US
Date: Thu, 06 Dec 2018 17:35:13 GMT
Expires: Thu, 06 Dec 2018 17:35:13 GMT
Server: meinheld/0.6.1
Strict-Transport-Security: max-age=63072000
X-Content-Type-Options: nosniff
X-Frame-Options: DENY
X-XSS-Protection: 1; mode=block
Vary: Accept-Encoding,Cookie
X-Cache: Error from cloudfront

<!DOCTYPE html>… (contains a site-customized page helping the user to find the
                  missing resource)
```

Response status codes

HTTP response status codes indicate if a specific HTTP request has been successfully completed. Responses are grouped into five classes: informational responses, successful responses, redirects, client errors, and servers errors.

1XX Informational	
100	Continue
101	Switching Protocols
102	Processing

2XX Success	
200	OK
201	Created
202	Accepted
203	Non-authoritative Information
204	No Content
205	Reset Content
206	Partial Content
207	Multi-Status
208	Already Reported
226	IM Used

3XX Redirectional	
300	Multiple Choices
301	Moved Permanently
302	Found
303	See Other
304	Not Modified
305	Use Proxy
307	Temporary Redirect
308	Permanent Redirect

4XX Client Error	
400	Bad Request
401	Unauthorized
402	Payment Required
403	Forbidden
404	Not Found
405	Method Not Allowed
406	Not Acceptable
407	Proxy Authentication Required
408	Request Timeout

4XX Client Error Continued	
409	Conflict
410	Gone
411	Length Required
412	Precondition Failed
413	Payload Too Large
414	Request-URI Too Long
415	Unsupported Media Type
416	Requested Range Not Satisfiable
417	Expectation Failed
418	I'm a teapot
421	Misdirected Request
422	Unprocessable Entity
423	Locked
424	Failed Dependency
426	Upgrade Required
428	Precondition Required
429	Too Many Requests
431	Request Header Fields Too Large
444	Connection Closed Without Response
451	Unavailable For Legal Reasons
499	Client Closed Request

5XX Server Error	
500	Internal Server Error
501	Not Implemented
502	Bad Gateway
503	Service Unavailable
504	Gateway Timeout
505	HTTP Version Not Supported
506	Variant Also Negotiates
507	Insufficient Storage
508	Loop Detected
510	Not Extended
511	Network Authentication Required
599	Network Connect Timeout Error

This lesson was adapted from MDN Web Docs: https://developer.mozilla.org/en-US/docs/Web/HTTP/Session